of its prosperous Mediterranean trade. The Arabs brought spices from the east and then transported them by land to the ports of the Mediterranean region. Italian city-states such as Venice and Genoa profited immensely from this trade. Following the expansion of trade, a strong network of banking and financial institutions too developed in Italy. In this context, new ideas leading to the Renaissance, Reformation and Exploration through sea voyages were born.

8.1(b) Invention of the Printing Press

The invention of the printing press accelerated the process of modernisation. Earlier, manuscripts were written by hand on animal skin called *Vellum*. Only the privileged few could access them. Johannes Gutenberg (1394-1468 A.D. (C.E.)) invented the printing press in Germany in the middle of the fifteenth century. The printing press enabled the production of multiple copies of a manuscript and their spread all over Western Europe. In less than fifty years after the invention of the Gutenberg printing press, about six million books had been printed. The invention of printing press not only spread knowledge widely, but also promoted critical thinking.



Gutenberg's Printing Press

8.1(c) Fall of Constantinople

In 1453 A.D. (C.E.), Constantinople, the capital of the Byzantine Empire, was captured by the Ottoman Turks. This acted as a catalyst for the birth of Renaissance. It also led to the discovery of new land routes. Following the Turkish occupation, a number of scholars, artists and artisans left Constantinople, which was for many centuries the cultural capital of the Western world, to the Italian city states.

8.2 Renaissance

With the coming of the scholars and artists from Constantinople there was a surge of enthusiasm and interest in studying classical literature and art of Greeks and Romans in the Italian city states. This creative upsurge was reflected in their writings, art, architecture and music. This cultural florescence is known as the *renaissance*. The origin of the word renaissance is from the Italian word *renascita* meaning *rebirth*. Greek scholar Manuel Chrysoloras who taught Greek classics in Italy, Guarino and Giovanni Aurispa, to name just a few, visited Constantinople several times to collect Greek manuscripts. Later they printed what they collected. This provided stimulus to the flowering of renaissance.

8.2(a) Why Italy became the birth place of Renaissance?

Italian city-states such as Florence, Milan, Venice, and Rome profited immensely from the Mediterranean trade. This led to the emergence of a rich and vibrant urban culture. The rich families of these city states such as Medicis of Florence patronized literature, art and music. The highpoint of this period was between 1475 A.D. (C.E.) and 1525 A.D. (C.E.). Italian universities taught humanities viz., lingustic, grammar, rhetoric, history, science and ethics, which prepared the students for public life, commerce and administration. The study of humanities was so popular in the Italian Universities that students from all over Europe flocked there. Classical Greek and Latin literature introduced the idea of *Humanism* which got reflected in the paintings, sculptures, architecture, music and writings of that period.

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